

STATE REVIEW LEARNINGS:

REACH UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

On-Site Review: January 29–30, 2025

WHAT'S IN THIS REPORT?

The report uses evidence from state data collection and an onsite review to examine educator preparation program performance. The information in this report is meant to inform a continuous improvement process that takes educator preparation programs closer to the goals needed to serve Arkansas's students.

This report rates the EPP on all three Standards of the Arkansas Education Preparation Provider State Review Framework, which are fundamental to support teacher candidates in their journey to becoming successful teachers who meet the needs of students in Arkansas:

- Standard 1, "Candidate Recruitment and Completion," is rated primarily with quantitative data from state data collection.
- For Standard 2, "Preparing Candidates Effectively," criteria to assess performance results from document review, observations, and focus group conversations with stakeholders, including teacher preparation program deans, candidates, current school leaders and teachers, faculty, and the DESE staff.
- The ratings for Standard 3, "Supporting Workforce Needs," are based on state data reporting.

Performance Levels are defined as follows:

Performance Level	Average Score Equivalent
EXCEEDS	Average score equivalent to exceeds on two of three standards or indicators
MEETS	Average score equivalent to meets on all three standards or indicators
APPROACHING	Average score equivalent to approaching on one standard or indicator and meets on the other two
BELOW	Average score equivalent to below on one standard or indicator and approaching on the other two

REACH UNIVERSITY

TRADITIONAL

Overall Performance Level		
N/A		
* There's insufficient data from Standard 1 and Standard 3 to calculate an overall performance score.		
Performance Levels by Standard		
Standard 1: Recruitment & Completion	Standard 2: Preparing Candidates Effectively	Standard 3: Supporting Workforce Needs
N/A	MEETS	N/A

STANDARD 1: RECRUITMENT & COMPLETION

Standard 1 Performance Level		
N/A		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 1.1 Plans	Indicator 1.2 Recruitment	Indicator 1.3 Completion
MEETS	APPROACHING	N/A
Recommendations		
Reach was rated 'Exceeds Expectations' on Criterion 1.2a due to the increase in enrollment during the reviewed years. However, it will be important for Reach to monitor the nearly 50% decline in new enrollees from 2022 to 2023. Additionally, Reach should consider offering licensure programs in areas identified as shortages in Arkansas, as outlined in Criterion 1.2b.		

INDICATOR 1.1: PLANS

Criteria 1.1a: Programs have formal plans to meet the targets described in the state review framework (i.e., Standards 1-3) and show evidence of acting on their plans	
Performance Level	Explanation
MEETS	Reach presented an Annual Plan that addressed all indicators of the state framework. Their goals showed evidence of action; however, their standard 1 data could have been more directly addressed.

INDICATOR 1.2: RECRUITMENT

Criteria 1.2a: Programs meet annual recruitment targets that align with their program size and Arkansas's workforce needs			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Growth in 3yr Average Enrollment	Performance Level
Percentage growth in 3yr average enrollment	10%	100%	EXCEEDS

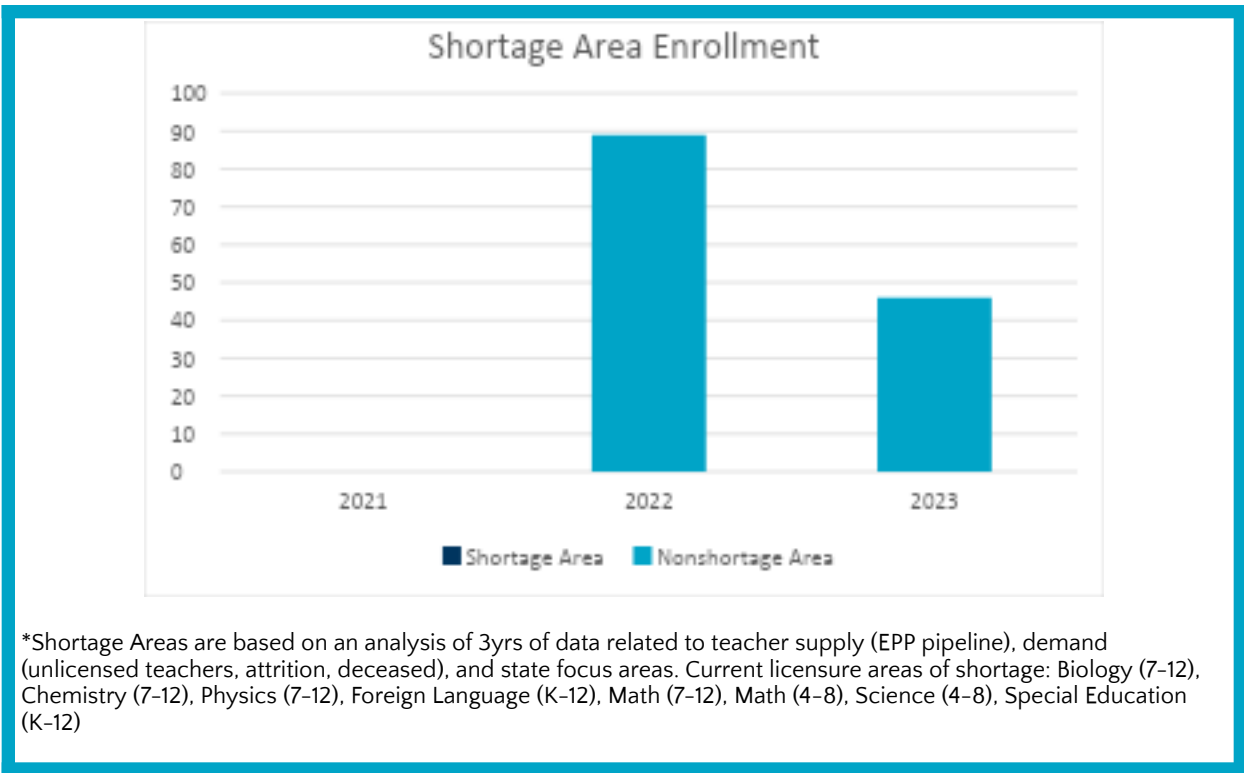
Enrollment

Metric is the percentage growth between blue and green boxes.

Year	Percentage Growth
2018	0%
2019	0%
2020	0%
2021	0%
2022	88%
2023	48%

*The enrollment growth target was established with the aim of closing the sizeable gap between EPP completers and those leaving the classroom over the next 10yrs. EPPs can earn a “Meets” rating by demonstrating positive program enrollment growth (i.e., growth greater than zero) and an “Exceeds” rating by demonstrating growth greater than 10 percent.

Criteria 1.2b: Programs recruit candidates for Arkansas certification shortage areas in proportion to the need			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percent of New Enrollees in Shortage Areas	Performance Level
Percentage of program candidates recruited in shortage areas	24%	0%	BELOW



INDICATOR 1.3: COMPLETION

Criteria 1.3a: Candidates have high rates of completion			
Metric	Target	EPP's 3-Year Completion Rate	Performance Level
Three-year average completion rate	74%	N/A	N/A

Standard 2: PREPARING CANDIDATES EFFECTIVELY

Standard 2 Performance Level		
MEETS		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 2.1 Coursework	Indicator 2.2 Clinical Experiences	Indicator 2.3 Development
APPROACHING	MEETS	MEETS
Recommendations		
Reach University provided evidence to highlight its commitment to developing candidates to prepare them with the knowledge, systems and structures they need to teach in Arkansas schools by aligning coursework with clinical experiences, providing a variety of field experiences and giving effective feedback to candidates. Candidates have clear goals and milestones to help them successfully complete the program and have the capacity to positively impact student growth. Recommendations to strengthen candidate preparation include: - Audit coursework for alignment to the Arkansas K-12 Academic Standards and ensure that candidates have opportunities to vertically align standards across grade bands. Audit coursework to incorporate Arkansas Teaching Standards and Arkansas Educator Competencies ensuring all candidates are familiar with them. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.1a Metric 2, Criteria 2.1b Metric 2)</i> - Evaluate program plans and update them as needed to ensure a clear and intentional sequence that shows a progressive increase in rigor. Ensure candidates receive the content and application of learning in a systematic design to fully support their growth in the classroom. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.1b Metric 1)</i> - Document a clear and intentional process to fully support teacher candidates who may fall behind in their coursework that allows EPP staff and the teacher candidate to actively monitor their progress to getting back on track <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 2.3a Metric 2)</i>		

INDICATOR 2.1: COURSEWORK

Criteria 2.1a: Candidates receive high-quality program coursework that is evidence-based
APPROACHING
Metric 1: Incorporation and demonstration of best practices around content instruction MEETS Coursework clearly and intentionally incorporates nationally recognized best practices around content instruction. Noted examples of HQIM were CKLA, Logic of English, and Sonday. The Science of Reading was evident in six of the nine syllabi presented. SoR examples included teaching the Five Essential Elements of Reading, dyslexia training, current brain research on how children learn to read and morphology instruction. Evidence-based practices were indicated in the use of social studies standards to create lesson plans. Courses utilized the research-based module, Tutorial Model, to teach coursework. Literacy courses follow the model provided by the Science of Reading research

with clear documentation of alignment across course work as seen in the “Foundations of Reading Competences Matrix. “High-Quality Instructional Materials (HQIM) Teacher Competencies- 2024” are incorporated throughout the course work.

In the Course Instructor focus group participants mentioned using the HQIM evaluation gateways from the DESE website, analysis of one HQIM as a model to analyze other curriculum, and annotating HQIM lessons.

Three out of the five courses observed clearly and intentionally utilized best practices. In The Clinical Residency: The Instructional Cycle Part I, the course instructor led conversations around utilizing HQIM for learner accommodations and made connections to best practices tied directly to Aspiring TESS domains 1a and 1b. The course instructor also spoke thoughtfully to programs like Lexia and Illustrative Math.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas K12 Standards in coursework as a foundation for teacher development
APPROACHING

Coursework somewhat familiarizes candidates with Arkansas K-12 Academic Standards; however, reviewers noted that in the documentation, submitted evidence was not the most recent for current state standards in math and ELA. InTASC standards and NIET standards are embedded in all courses and the unpacking of state standards in content instruction. The NIET and Arkansas TESS ATR crosswalk submitted demonstrates correlations for students. Examples noted are in Methods Establishing Foundations for T&L (OTM 221) which uses the current social studies state standards. Another example is in The Clinical Residency: The Instructional Cycle Part I (OTM 421) in a math lesson plan with archived Arkansas Standards. Reviewers noted that there was no direct reference to vertical alignment in the evidence submitted.

In the Coursework focus group, teacher candidates stated familiarity with the Arkansas Academic K-12 Standards and requirements to align standards to lessons in multiple courses. However, reviewers saw evidence of this in only one of the five course observations. Candidates practiced creating one sentence objectives from a variety of AR K-12 Standards across all elementary content areas during class and received feedback from their instructor, prior to completing an objective writing assignment. In the Methods Establishing Foundations for T&L (OTM221), the instructor spoke thoughtfully and fluently to standard progression and vertical alignment in response to candidate discussion, however, there was no evidence of vertical alignment being an intentional focus.

Criteria 2.1b: Candidates' coursework supports their development as a teacher
APPROACHING

Metric 1: Sequence and progression of courses
APPROACHING

Courses are somewhat sequenced across programs of study to build off previous coursework providing candidates an opportunity to show proficiency. The EPP submitted degree plan programs of study showing the progressions and sequencing of coursework and connections to program checkpoints and transitions. The BAGE degree is job-embedded with Years 1 and 2 focusing on general education and foundational teaching skills. Year 2 begins to immerse candidates in coursework to prepare for Praxis licensure exams. Year 3 is specifically designed to deepen content knowledge, with a strong focus on the Science of Reading and targeted Praxis exam preparation. The final year includes a year-long clinical residency, where candidates teach and receive weekly coaching. Due to the clustering of content subject area courses, reviewers did not observe that the coursework sequence demonstrates an increase in content area rigor as candidates develop in their experiences and learning. A strong focus on Praxis preparation is evident early in the program with pedagogy focus occurring in the last two semesters.

In the Coursework focus group, candidates stated multiple times that courses help prepare them for the Praxis exam. Candidates described examples where something was learned in a content course and then directly applied to the classroom. All responses were specific to the current content course, and when prompted about previous semesters, participants were not able to recall specific examples. There was not a strong memory of examples. However, the focus group did state they learned content that could be directly applied on the job. In the Course Instructor focus group, participants described how the courses were structured and designed. They discussed how the college readiness course prepared students throughout the program and how all work at intermediate and advanced levels led to clinical experiences. During the clinical experience, a capstone research project pulls together knowledge from

prior semesters and applies that to their current employment. However, reviewers did not observe enough evidence to support that this was sufficient for candidates to show proficiency across their content area courses.

Metric 2: Incorporation and utilization of Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards in coursework
APPROACHING

Coursework somewhat incorporates Arkansas Educator Competencies and Arkansas Teaching Standards which is shown in the alignment matrix that serves as a clear guide for understanding how each course supports the development of essential teaching skills and competencies. The Curriculum Matrix indicates all ten standards of ATS/InTASC mapped across multiple courses. Candidates are taught to break down essential standards and align these standards in their lessons and assessments to meet the knowledge and skills of their required licensure area. Candidates are also required to rate themselves using the Arkansas ATR, fostering deep reflection and identifying areas for growth to further develop their teaching practice. Course syllabi (examples, OTM221, OTM430, OTM 421A/B) include links to Arkansas Competencies and InTASC standards with course alignment.

In the Course Instructor focus group, Courses clearly use NIET standards which align to Arkansas Educator Competencies and Teaching Standards; however, participants noted this was the first semester implementing the Arkansas Educator competencies. The university has made steps to improve, but the EPP is currently approaching this metric.

In the Culture and Collaboration (OTM 440) course observation, the instructor prompted students with a question around the objective and directed them to look through the ATR and find evidence of where it connects to the learning environment. Candidates provided their responses, and the instructor solidified the connections between learning and ATR and InTASC (though not explicitly stated as InTASC, components were strongly observed).

Metric 3: Alignment of coursework to clinical experience
MEETS

Coursework is clearly and intentionally aligned to clinical experience. Multiple courses provide candidates with clinical experiences through assignments that impact the ability to support struggling learners in Tiers 2 and 3 and understand special education laws and rights. Examples include Development and Characteristics of Learners, Instructional Strategies, Planning & Assessment for Learners with Exceptionalities, and Professional, Ethical, and Legal Practices for Special Education. Candidates engage in creating classroom management plans, community engagement projects, and completing their education research for the capstone project.

The “ED PREP Overview” provided by Reach describes the process for admitting candidates into their program: validating employment within a school system and having 15plus hours of weekly classroom access in a partnering school that has an active MOU in the state of Arkansas.

Evidence was observed that candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment with their clinical supervisor and course instructors. Each candidate participates in the POP cycle four times during their residency year with an experienced clinical supervisor. Pre and post conferences are conducted to provide feedback, reflection and opportunities for coaching from clinical supervisors.

In the Course Instructor focus group, participants explained that as a job embedded program, the courses align candidate learning with application to their employment. Instructors described how courses begin at a theoretical level and quickly move to application. Candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment with their clinical supervisor and course instructors. Through the Tutorial Model, candidates take the learning, observe in the field, and then return to class to share and reflect on what they learned. Theory to practice was reiterated multiple times.

Candidates in the Coursework focus group also described opportunities to reflect on observations. In their reflection, candidates suggest changes or revisions to improve the lesson.

In Clinical Residency: The Instructional Cycle Part I (OTM 421), candidates consistently have opportunities to reflect on and articulate the alignment with their clinical supervisor and course instructors. The instructor encouraged candidates to share what they are seeing in the field and in their schools. Candidates were asked to share strategies of differentiation they are seeing in HQIM implementation.

Criteria 2.1c: Candidates are provided with knowledgeable and effective course instructors

MEETS

Metric 1: Quality of course instructors

MEETS

Most course instructors show deep knowledge of Arkansas Academic K-12 Standards, content knowledge, and content pedagogy. Most course instructors have a terminal degree and hold an educator or administrator license. Most instructors have been trained in the Aspiring Teacher Rubric, and specific, recent professional learning is documented for all instructors.

In the Culture and Classroom Management (OTM 430) course observation, instructors consistently gave pedagogy examples and elaborated on specific topics. For example, with the classroom management plan, both instructors provided a specific example of procedures and explained how those would need elaboration to provide anyone reading the plan, a complete understanding. They also referenced journal articles, nationally recognized models (CASEL website), and specific look fors when determining proficiency.

In The Clinical Residency: The Instructional Cycle Part I (OTM 421), the lesson focused on using HQIM, and the instructor made direct connections between course content and the Aspiring TESS rubric. When candidates struggled to respond to a question about information they may need about students with exceptional needs, the instructor provided specific suggestions such as using RTI data and how previous interventions impacted student performance.

In Methods Establishing Foundations for T&L (OTM 221), the instructor was able to speak thoughtfully about the requirements of each K-12 Standard, as well as how those Standards progress throughout the K-6 grade band. She added additional context for the Standards in response to examples given by candidates.

Metric 2: Effectiveness of course instructors

MEETS

Some course instructors show evidence of strong facilitation of coursework and providing feedback and support. The documentation submitted was limited. It provided an evaluation of one course instructor; however, the evaluation was detailed. No examples of feedback or candidate support were provided in the evidence documents from course instructors.

In the Coursework focus group, participants gave examples of their course instructors' facilitation. They cited using breakout rooms for small group discussion and other engagement platforms such as Pear Deck. The focus group stated that most instructors provide feedback on assignments that is encouraging and that instructors are responsive and willing to stay after class for additional support.

In The Clinical Residency: The Instructional Cycle Part I (OTM 421) observation, the reviewers noted that the instructor modeled best-practice, starting the lesson with the goal for the day, integrating the use of a timer on screen, allowing appropriate wait time during questions, and integrating collaborative partner activities in breakout rooms.

INDICATOR 2.2: CLINICAL EXPERIENCES

Criteria 2.2a: Candidates are provided clinical experiences throughout their program that support their development as a teacher

MEETS

Metric 1: The sequence of clinical experiences

MEETS

The overall sequence of clinical experiences intentionally builds off previous experiences and provides opportunities for learning and development. Candidates complete two semesters of their clinical residency. The first semester requires candidates to be in a school three days per week, and this increases to four days per week in the second semester. During the first semester, candidates support in the classroom with bell work, small groups, review sessions, mini lessons, etc. In the second semester, candidates begin teaching at least half of the class period, gradually working their way up to teaching the full class period. Clinical Supervisors confirmed this in their focus

group by describing the progression. In Residency 1, candidates start with observation and curriculum familiarization, then progress through POP cycles with increasing classroom time using HQIM. Candidates are observed twice in Residency 1. In Residency 2, they teach more frequently with less time observing their mentor and receive two additional formal observations.

In addition to their clinical residency semesters, course syllabi show evidence of required on-the-job field experiences. For example, in Development and Characteristics of Learners (DEP 400), candidates are required to complete three field-based opportunities in apprenticeship learning.

In the Clinical Supervisor focus group, one supervisor shared that because candidates are employed in schools, they work to create expanded experiences beyond their regular roles. Reach University coordinates with principals to ensure candidates have time in mentor teacher classrooms outside of their school-based jobs (e.g., moving from paraprofessional or Aspiring teacher roles into actual teaching experiences). The supervisor emphasized how a candidate's experiences progressively build to include more time in mentor classrooms.

Metric 2: The variety of clinical experiences MEETS

The overall variety of clinical experiences provides adequate opportunities for candidates to work with students with varied learning needs. Reach University's handbook shared information on candidates' support in working with students with varied learning needs, including those with IEPs. Candidates already hold school-based positions and, therefore, are exposed to a variety of students in various settings through their job, and additional opportunities are also provided throughout their field experiences.

In the Clinical Supervisor focus group, one participant shared that she was impressed with the range of clinical opportunities candidates experience. The supervisor observed candidates implementing their learning across multiple environments including inclusion settings and small group instruction. She noted that candidates regularly share these varied experiences with each other and their supervisors during class discussions.

Supervisors spoke about candidates' varied experiences across classrooms and with struggling readers. Across the clinical supervisor and clinical experience focus groups, participants agreed they have ample opportunities to experience a variety of students with varied learning needs. One participant in the Clinical Experience focus group said, "I had a chance to work with kids at different levels through small groups and I got to observe (as a para) a curriculum called 'Take Flight' which supported students struggling with dyslexia."

Criteria 2.2b: Candidates across the program are provided with an effective clinical internship MEETS

Metric 1: The effectiveness of experienced mentor teachers MEETS

Most experienced mentor teachers are equipped and have the skills to properly support and develop a candidate's pedagogical development. Reach University works with over 35 experienced mentor teachers. In the Clinical Experience focus group, participants shared strong examples of how their experienced mentor teachers support them in the classroom. One participant shared how her mentor effectively facilitates collaboration across multiple classrooms, "Since I work in different fourth and fifth grade math and literacy classrooms, my mentor has worked with me to build lesson plans and serves as a bridge to work with the other teachers where she 'pushes in.'" Another participant described comprehensive support from her mentor teacher who actively models instruction and provides regular guidance. She noted her mentor teacher models lessons for her if she needs guidance or has questions. They have structured support through a standing meeting during her planning time for questions and weekly check-ins. The participant also said her mentor ensures she has access to student data, and they have frequent conversations about supporting individual students.

Note: By 2026–2027, experienced mentor teachers working with year-long residents must have received the DESE-recognized coaching training. [Arkansas Novice Teacher Mentoring Manual](#)

Metric 2: Quality of selection process for experienced mentor teachers APPROACHING

A partial process is in place to select experienced mentor teachers. The “Clinical Residency Handbook” outlines qualification requirements for experienced mentor teachers which includes holding a standard license, having a minimum of three years of teaching experience, evidence of annual ratings of “effective or higher”, and documentation of completing DESE recognized coaching trainings. In the evidence, the EPP shared that the selection of mentor teachers is a collaborative effort between and each cooperating district/school, with the building principal choosing the mentor alongside the Reach candidate. Reach University facilitates a mentor orientation each semester which outlines residency expectations, the mentoring process, and how mentors can best support residents.

In the Partnership focus group, one administrator shared that they look for teachers with the master/lead designation to select mentor teachers, saying they are the most effective teachers in the building. Administrators did not indicate any other formal selection process for mentor teachers.

Metric 3: Quality of clinical supervisors

MEETS

Most program clinical supervisors demonstrate effective instructional practices and coaching with a positive impact. Of the 10 clinical supervisors, seven have training on the Aspiring Teacher rubric, eight are trained in Diane Sweeney’s Student-Centered Coaching model and all have SoR training. In candidate evaluation surveys, all respondents (four or five per clinical supervisor), said their clinical supervisor is “extremely or very knowledgeable”.

In all four coaching observations, reviewers noted evidence of strong instructional and coaching practices. One reviewer observed the clinical supervisor effectively coaching the candidate by providing targeted feedback that led to noticeable growth in lesson planning, instructional strategies, and assessment practices. Their guidance encouraged the candidate to implement new techniques, such as encoding strategies, and to shift toward more student independence gradually. In the pre-conference of another observation, the reviewer saw that the supervisor recognized progress while pushing for continued growth. The clinical supervisor stated, “I love that you put questioning as a strength this time because that was your refinement for last time. So, I’m glad that you’re feeling more confident in that... you’re getting there... You’re doing a good job.”

In the Clinical Experience focus group, all participants felt supported, and two participants shared specific examples. One participant shared that she has received support around student learning. The supervisor provided practical guidance and maintained frequent contact, two to three times a week via text message with her mentor.

Metric 4: Quality of feedback to candidates

MEETS

Candidates consistently receive high-quality feedback from their clinical supervisor. Clinical supervisors are required to conduct at least four observations during the clinical residency rooted in the Aspiring Teacher Rubric and NIET rubric. Each week, candidates complete a weekly coaching journal that supervisors and experienced mentor teachers are expected to review and write feedback. In the Clinical Experience focus group, one participant said “each week we have a Google document where we record our weekly experiences and strengths and weaknesses. The mentor goes through it and engages in feedback and conversation with me.”

In the Clinical Supervisor focus group, one participant provided a specific example showing how feedback builds across multiple sources. She discussed a lesson plan feedback scenario where the mentor had given initial feedback. The candidate then sought additional supervisor feedback regarding the balance between HQIM fidelity and differentiation, demonstrating how feedback from multiple sources (mentor and supervisor) is coordinated to support candidate growth.

Reviewers observed strong feedback in their coaching observations. The clinical supervisor provided written feedback in the Learning Management System prior to the pre- and post-conferences. During the live conferences, the supervisor frequently referenced previous feedback and how it connected to current practice. “I want to celebrate this because this was a refinement from your previous POP Cycle and now, we’re celebrating it as a reinforcement.” Feedback and self-assessment are aligned to both the Arkansas and NIET aspiring teacher rubrics.

Note: The Aspiring Teacher Rubric must be in use by EPPs by the 2024–25 academic year.

Criteria 2.2c: Strong partnerships exist between the EPP and K12 schools and districts that facilitate the development of strong candidates

APPROACHING

Metric 1: Quality of partnership with districts/schools

APPROACHING

Collaborative processes are in place with some districts to co-construct the clinical internship. Candidates typically complete their clinical internship in the school where they already work, and the EPP establishes an MOU with that school. They identify a point of contact for the school and work together to determine the clinical experience for the candidate. The EPP hosts a quarterly virtual meeting with school leaders to share program updates. In fall 2024, Reach launched a monthly newsletter to all partners to share updates and formalize a communication channel.

Participants in the Partnership focus group agree some collaborative processes exist. The three district partners in the focus group agreed that mentor teachers received training from Reach University necessary for supporting clinical residents and noted that the training had been improved by implementation of their previous feedback.

In the Clinical Supervisor focus group, a participant shared that they are working to improve collaboration between supervisors and mentors, noting it was a “hole” in their system. The EPP recently began requiring monthly check-ins between supervisors and mentors. Previously, mentors and supervisors would only email if there was an issue.

In the Experienced Mentor Teacher focus group, although participants had communicated with someone from the EPP, they were unclear if it was with their candidate’s clinical supervisor or someone else, and shared they would like more collaboration with someone at Reach to better support their candidate.

Metric 2: Support and development for clinical supervisors

MEETS

Collaborative processes are in place to support and develop effective clinical supervisors. Seven of the 11 clinical supervisors received training on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric and eight of the 11 have attended Diane Sweeney’s Student Centered Coaching training. Reach University provided session agendas and recordings for supervisor weekly planning sessions where supervisors “review expectations, refine POP Cycle feedback, and collaborate on guiding questions.”

In the Clinical Supervisor focus group, four out of five participants are actively embedded in schools where they receive professional development from their local school employers. They also noted professional development provided by Reach University including structured ongoing development through twice monthly meetings in role-specific groups and specific training on assessment tools.

INDICATOR 2.3: DEVELOPMENT

Criteria 2.3a: Candidates are successful with their program coursework

APPROACHING

Metric 1: Candidate proficiency in coursework

MEETS

Most candidates show proficiency in coursework requirements. 100% (10/10) of candidates enter the program with high GPAs (>3.7) and exit with equally high GPAs (>3.7) demonstrating proficiency.

Metric 2: Quality of candidate support across coursework

APPROACHING

Candidates are inconsistently provided with an individualized support plan if their coursework requirements are not on track. Evidence was provided of an individual support plan, and it was noted that the supervisor met with the resident to explain the rationale and develop action steps for improvement. However, there was no evidence provided of how candidates are identified, description of progress monitoring, or data illustrating if residents on PGPs are successful. Although there is evidence of a university system (Google form) to provide individualized support when candidates fall behind in coursework, reviewers did not observe data to support the success rate of these candidates or examples of what individualized support looks like.

In the Course Instructor focus group, participants discussed wrap around services (ticketing system, wellness coaching, course analytics, etc.) that are university specific. However, participants did not share examples of individualized plans in which candidates have some ownership.

Criteria 2.3b: Candidates are successful in their clinical internship

MEETS

Metric 1: Candidate attainment of clinical internship goals and milestones

MEETS

Reach University has a set of goals and milestones for candidates' clinical internship. The "4-Year Learning Continuum" clearly outlines goals and skills each candidate should be able to demonstrate at the end of each year including the following skill areas: Academic Writing and Research, Communication, Critical Thinking, and Professionalism and Ethics. There are multiple assessments in coursework that are required to successfully complete the program including the classroom management plan project (OTM 430), community engagement project (OTM 440), and action research capstone (OTM 450). Major goals include earning a rating of "effective" on the Arkansas Aspiring Teacher Rubric, passing all Praxis and Foundation of Reading tests, and converting to a standard license.

In the Clinical Experience focus group, one participant indicated that her supervisor "is very focused on NIET and TESS and reaching 'proficiency'" while another participant identified key programmatic milestones including "making sure we pass Praxis and are ready for the Foundations of Reading test" along with developing skills in "differentiated lesson plans and implementation." In the Clinical Supervisor focus group, all four participants could provide examples of the goals and milestones and how candidates demonstrate success. One participant emphasized that expectations are clearly communicated through multiple formats. They mentioned the Clinical Residency Handbook serves as a resource that explains expectations and a reference for candidates to "track their progress and meet milestones".

Another noted that candidates are successfully reaching program milestones saying that her candidates have all met the EPP goals and milestones because they have made it to "Residency 2". She estimated that "95% made it from Residency 1 to Residency 2 in current cohorts," showing a strong retention rate and successful advancement.

Metric 2: Candidate impact on student growth

MEETS

There is adequate evidence that candidates have the capacity to impact student growth. Candidates are expected to create lesson plans using Reach's standard template that prompts candidates to consider the lesson's alignment to Arkansas Academic K-12 Standards, formative assessments, differentiation strategies, and a reflection on learning. Candidates evaluate student work samples, analyze students' performance on assessments, and maintain anecdotal notes and tracking measures for performance-based expectations. These are reviewed during candidates' post-conference coaching sessions with their clinical supervisor. Of the samples provided, about 62% of students achieved proficiency on one assessment, about 73% met expectations in a phonics lesson, and about 94% met expectations in a lesson on shapes.

In the Clinical Supervisor focus group, participants provided examples of how candidates are impacting student growth. One supervisor explained that pre- and post-conferences involve analyzing student data and work samples to assess the candidates' impact on student learning. This structured approach ensures that candidates use real evidence to inform their instructional choices and adapt their teaching to meet student needs. Another supervisor shared their approach of discussing trends in student learning with candidates during POP meetings to ensure that teacher candidates receive targeted feedback on their instructional impact. This creates a learning loop where teacher candidates refine their methods based on observed student progress.

In a coaching pre-observation, the candidate talked about her assessment design including "multiple choice, fill in the blank, open response, and true and false questions". The supervisor commented that assessment was the candidate's reinforcement area and gave affirmation, noting the rigor of the assessment. In the post-conference, the supervisor discussed the alignment of the lesson to the state assessment. She stated, "You had a strong alignment between what they're going to do on their state test to what you're doing in your classroom. You're working towards preparing them." The supervisor discussed how the candidate's work impacted student learning and made a connection to her candidate's work and their collaboration with another teacher who is reinforcing the same material in a different class.

Metric 3: Candidate proficiency in effective teaching skills

MEETS

Most candidates receive a score of "effective" on the Aspiring Teacher Rubric at the end of their clinical internship. Of the EPP's three most recent completers (December 2024), only two (66%) had an overall rating of "effective". However, of the five candidates included in the recent samples of Arkansas Aspiring Teacher Rubric ratings, all five (100%) candidates had an overall rating of "effective."

Metric 4: Quality of candidate support across clinical internship

MEETS

Struggling candidates are provided with an individualized support plan if their development is not on track. There is evidence of an individualized growth plan including concrete action and measurable outcomes steps such as weekly focused coaching journals and annotated HQIM plans.

In the Clinical Experience focus group, participants shared that support includes collaborating with their mentor, supervisor, and peers in the program. One participant noted this goes beyond teaching aspects to help them develop their teacher identity. This was reinforced by another participant by describing multiple layers of support including "consistent feedback, modeling, co-teaching, encouragement, open conversations, resources, strategies." However, a third participant felt less supported because her supervisor is not in Arkansas and "cannot answer AR specific questions for AR licensure."

Some high performing candidates receive opportunities and feedback that encourage their retention. High performing candidates are recognized for their achievements during the clinical internship in multiple ways including an Award of Distinctive Excellence and selection as commencement speakers. Participants in the focus group did not provide any additional examples of recognition or opportunities, outside of feedback from their mentor teacher or clinical supervisor.

STANDARD 3: SUPPORTING WORKFORCE NEEDS

Standard 3 Performance Level		
N/A		
Indicator Performance Levels		
Indicator 3.1 Licensure	Indicator 3.2 Employment	Indicator 3.3 Effectiveness
N/A	N/A	N/A
Recommendations		
Recommendations include: - Establish programmatic support to ensure that traditional program completers are prepared to obtain standard licensure immediately following completion, including passing the content exam on their first try. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.1a and 3.1c)</i> - Analyze EPP Completer Supervisor Survey and EPP Completer Survey results to identify specific domains and components for which both supervisors and candidates do not feel their program prepared them well to become a teacher. <i>(Focus Areas: Criteria 3.3a and 3.3b)</i>		

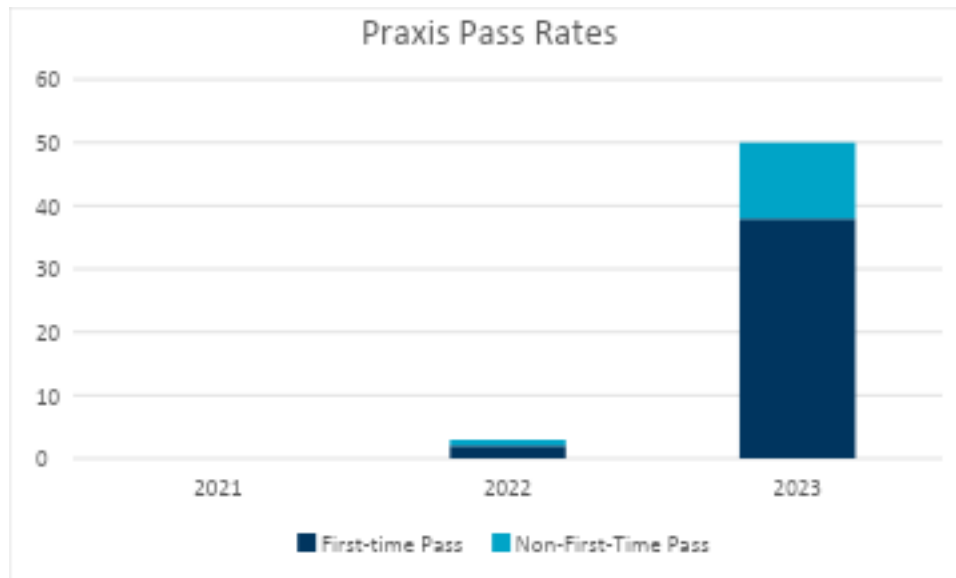
INDICATOR 3.1: LICENSURE

Criteria 3.1a: A high proportion of program candidates obtain a standard license			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who have earned a standard license	80%	N/A	N/A
Criteria 3.1b: A high proportion of alternative route enrollees are provisionally licensed			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Licensed	Performance Level

Percentage of employed alternative route enrollees who are provisionally licensed	73%	N/A	N/A
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Criteria 3.1c: A high proportion of traditional program candidates pass the content exam in their area on the first try

Metric	Target	EPP's First-Time Pass Percentage	Performance Level
Percentage of first-time licensure exam test takers that pass on their first try	66%	75.5%	EXCEEDS



INDICATOR 3.2: EMPLOYMENT

Criteria 3.2a: A high proportion of completers are employed in Arkansas public schools			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in Arkansas public schools in their first three years after completion	68%	N/A	N/A
Criteria 3.2b: A high proportion of completers work in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage Employed Priority	Performance Level
Percentage of completers who are licensed and gain employment in high-priority Arkansas public school districts and subjects in their first three years after completion	39%	N/A	N/A
*Priority Employment is employment in a high-need subject area and/or geographical shortage area. Shortage Areas are based on an analysis of 3yrs of data related to teacher supply (EPP pipeline) and demand (unlicensed teachers, attrition, deceased) and state focus areas. Current subject shortage areas for employment: Secondary Science, Foreign Language, Secondary Math, Middle School Math, Middle School Science, and Special Education. Current geographical shortage areas are school districts located in the following co-op regions: Arkansas River ESC, Great Rivers ESC, Pulaski Co Schools, Southeast AR ESC.			
Criteria 3.2c: Program completers remain in the classroom for multiple years			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Years of Experience, 3 Years After Completion	Performance Level

Program completers' average licensed teaching experience in Arkansas's public schools 3 years after completion	1.8	N/A	N/A

INDICATOR 3.3: EFFECTIVENESS

Criteria 3.3a: School leaders rate program completers that they hire as effective classroom teachers			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
School leaders' perception of program completer effectiveness based on responses to the EPP Completer Supervisor Survey conducted annually by the DESE	78%	N/A	N/A
Criteria 3.3b: Completers feel that their program prepared them well to be a teacher			
Metric	Target	EPP's Average Percentage of Agree+ on all Survey Items	Performance Level
Program completers' perception of how well their program prepared them to be a teacher based on responses to the EPP Completer Survey conducted annually by the DESE	79%	N/A	N/A
Criteria 3.3c: A high proportion of program completers have above-average value-added scores			
Metric	Target	EPP's Percentage with Average Value-Added of 80+	Performance Level
Percentage of program completers who have above-average value-added scores in their first three years after completion	43%	N/A	N/A

